

Désirée's Baby

Kate Chopin · 1893

First published: Vogue, Jan 1893

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Cambridge International edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Bayou_Folk/Désirée's_Baby (revision 11819727), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Désirée's Baby suggest about race and identity?
- What does Désirée's Baby suggest about pride and cruelty?
- What does Désirée's Baby suggest about slavery?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Cambridge International

CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5

Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Désirée's Baby	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*race and identity* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Désirée's Baby

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Kate Chopin's life or times connects to race and identity in “Désirée's Baby”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (race and identity, pride and cruelty, slavery).

Standards: Cambridge International: see the unit standards

Author biography

Kate Chopin was born Katherine O'Flaherty in St. Louis on 8 February 1850. She married the Louisiana cotton trader Oscar Chopin and lived in New Orleans and Cloutierville among Creole and Cajun communities. Widowed in 1882 with six children, she returned to St. Louis and began writing; her stories appeared in Vogue and other magazines and were collected in Bayou Folk (1894). Her story The Awakening (1899), about a married woman's desire for independence, was condemned by reviewers. She died on 22 August 1904; her work was rediscovered in the 1960s.

Historical and cultural context

Set in antebellum Louisiana among the French Creole planter class, where racial categories and "one drop" ideas of ancestry determined status, and enslaved people were property.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published as "The Father of Désirée's Baby" in Vogue on 14 January 1893; collected in Bayou Folk (1894).

Then: Praised as local-colour fiction.

Now: Read as a sharp critique of racism and patriarchy, with one of the most famous twist endings.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Désirée, a foundling adopted by a wealthy family, marries the proud planter Armand Aubigny and has a son.

Main themes

- racism and identity.
- pride and power.
- irony.

Why it matters

It shows how racism destroys even those who enforce it.

Spoilers · teacher only

When the baby appears to be of mixed race, Armand rejects her; she walks into the bayou with the baby. Armand then finds a letter revealing that his own mother was Black.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open Désirée's Baby: What makes someone's identity: ancestry, upbringing or choice?
Prompt: Before we open Désirée's Baby: What makes someone's identity: ancestry, upbringing or choice?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
situational irony; foreshadowing; Creole; patriarchy.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Kate Chopin was born Katherine O'Flaherty in St. Louis on 8 February 1850. She married the Louisiana cotton trader Oscar Chopin and lived in New Orleans and Cloutierville among Creole and Cajun communities. Widowed in 1882 with six children, she returned to St. Louis and began writing; her stories appeared in Vogue and other magazines and were collected in Bayou Folk (1894). Her story The Awakening (1899), about a married woman's desire for independence, was condemned by reviewers. She died on 22 August 1904; her work was rediscovered in the 1960s. The world of the book. Set in antebellum Louisiana among the French Creole planter class, where racial categories and "one drop" ideas of ancestry determined status, and enslaved people were property. Publication and reception. First published as "The Father of Désirée's Baby" in Vogue on 14 January 1893; collected in Bayou Folk (1894). Then: Praised as local-colour fiction. Now: Read as a sharp critique of racism and patriarchy, with one of the most famous twist endings.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "it means that you are not white" slowly and put it in my own words: Armand tells Désirée that their child's appearance means she is not white. Next, craft. I notice the cold, simple words, said almost casually, carry a life-or-death sentence. The strongest word is "means": he treats appearance as proof, making a guess sound like fact. Then, effect. Why is this line the turning point of the story? My answer: In the society Chopin describes, one claim about race can erase a woman's identity; the line exposes how cruel and arbitrary that system is.

> *it means that you are not white (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "it means that you are not white" slowly and put it in my own words: Armand tells Désirée that their child's appearance means she is not white. Next, craft. I notice the cold, simple words, said almost casually, carry a life-or-death sentence. The strongest word is "means": he treats appearance as proof, making a guess sound like fact. Then, effect. Why is this line the turning point of the story? My answer: In the society Chopin describes, one claim about race can erase a woman's identity; the line exposes how cruel and arbitrary that system is.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Désirée, a foundling adopted by a wealthy family, marries the proud planter Armand Aubigny and has a son. Themes to track: racism and identity.: pride and power.: irony.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: race and identity. Prediction: Désirée, a foundling of unknown parentage, will be judged by Armand and the parish once her baby is born. Question: how will questions about origin change love in this Louisiana household?
Task: Set up a reading journal for Désirée's Baby: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: race and identity. Prediction: Désirée, a foundling of unknown parentage, will be judged by Armand and the parish once her baby is born. Question: how will questions about origin change love in this Louisiana household?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does Désirée's Baby still matter? It shows how racism destroys even those who enforce it.
Anchor question: Why might Désirée's Baby still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows how racism destroys even those who enforce it.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Chopin lived in Louisiana among Creole society after her marriage and wrote this story in 1893, decades after the Civil War. Why might she set a story about race in the years before the war? Answer: Accept answers such as: she knew Louisiana's strict racial hierarchy firsthand; setting it in slavery times let her criticize racism while seeming distant; readers in the 1890s faced new segregation laws.
Exit ticket: Chopin lived in Louisiana among Creole society after her marriage and wrote this story in 1893, decades after the Civil War. Why might she set a story about race in the years before the war?
Answer: Accept answers such as: she knew Louisiana's strict racial hierarchy firsthand; setting it in slavery times let her criticize racism while seeming distant; readers in the 1890s faced new segregation laws.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: Désirée's Baby.

Teacher notes · sources: Kate Chopin International Society (https://www.katechopin.org/); Britannica, "Kate Chopin" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Kate-Chopin); Kate Chopin International Society (https://www.katechopin.org/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The 14 January 1893 Vogue date is widely cited; verify against Kate Chopin International Society publication list.

Lesson 2: Désirée's Baby

Focus: racial pride destroying love

Objective: Students will analyze how irony develops in “Désirée's Baby” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Cambridge International: see the unit standards

Content note (slavery and racism, racial slurs absent but racial hierarchy central, implied suicide): Sensitive content: Slavery and racism; racial slurs absent but racial hierarchy central; implied suicide. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes slavery and racism; racial slurs absent but racial hierarchy central; implied suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this story is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Désirée, a foundling raised by the Valmondés, marries the proud planter Armand Aubigny. When their baby begins to show African ancestry, Armand turns cold and sends her away; she walks with the baby into the bayou and does not return. Burning her things, Armand finds a letter from his own mother, revealing that she belonged to 'the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery.'

Background: Published in Vogue in 1893 and set in antebellum Louisiana, where Creole society enforced rigid racial classification.

Significance: Its final reversal exposes the arbitrariness of racial categories.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How can a single fact change how people treat someone they love? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to racism and identity because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes slavery and racism; racial slurs absent but racial hierarchy central; implied suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: How can a single fact change how people treat someone they love?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to racism and identity because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: race is shown as a social construction.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: muslins — plain-woven cotton fabric; avalanche — a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain; narrowly — closely; carefully; obstacles — things that stand in the way; unjustly — in an unjust manner. "narrowly": Origin: an English formation from narrow + -ly. "obstacles": Origin of "obstacle": Old French obstacle; earlier Latin obstāculum. "unjustly": Origin: an English formation from unjust + -ly.
Words: muslins: plain-woven cotton fabric · avalanche: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain · narrowly: closely; carefully · obstacles: things that stand in the way · unjustly: in an unjust manner

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Vogue in 1893 and set in antebellum Louisiana, where Creole society enforced rigid racial classification. Its final reversal exposes the arbitrariness of racial categories. Irony: The man who rejects his wife for her "race" is himself of mixed ancestry. Foreshadowing: Armand's darkness, his mother living in Paris. Characterization: Armand's cruelty to enslaved people and his love that turns to hate. Watch for the bonfire: Armand burning her things, trying to destroy the evidence.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "it means that you are not white" slowly and put it in my own words: Désirée, frightened, asks her husband what it means that he says she is not white. Next, craft. I notice the sentence is short and plain, but it carries the whole weight of the story's racial law. The strongest word is "white": everything in her world, marriage, safety, love, depends on this one label. Then, effect. What is Désirée really asking Armand when she repeats these words? My answer: When Désirée repeats Armand's words, she is really asking whether he believes she is not white and whether he still loves her; the line shows how quickly a racial label can destroy her place and his love.

> *it means that you are not white* *(Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "it means that you are not white" slowly and put it in my own words: Désirée, frightened, asks her husband what it means that he says she is not white. Next, craft. I notice the sentence is short and plain, but it carries the whole weight of the story's racial law. The strongest word is "white": everything in her world, marriage, safety, love, depends on this one label. Then, effect. What is Désirée really asking Armand when she repeats these words? My answer: When Désirée repeats Armand's words, she is really asking whether he believes she is not white and whether he still loves her; the line shows how quickly a racial label can destroy her place and his love.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The letter's phrase reveals how slavery's ideology made race a "brand." Ask: How does this line connect to racism and identity? Expected: Race is shown as a social construction. (The final letter.)

> *belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery* *(Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The letter's phrase reveals how slavery's ideology made race a "brand."
Ask: How does this line connect to racism and identity?
Expected answer: Race is shown as a social construction. (The final letter.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for irony, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about racial pride destroying love? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Désirée's Baby develops the idea of racial pride destroying love. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. When the text says "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery" (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50), it shows this directly. Armand accuses Désirée, "it means that you are not white," but the final letter shows his own mother "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery."
Task: Annotate the story for irony, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about racial pride destroying love? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Désirée's Baby develops the idea of racial pride destroying love. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. When the text says "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery" (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50), it shows this directly. Armand accuses Désirée, "it means that you are not white," but the final letter shows his own mother "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How can a single fact change how people treat someone they love? Ask: did Armand know?
Anchor question: How can a single fact change how people treat someone they love?
Facilitation: Ask: did Armand know?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about racial pride destroying love? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. ("belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery", Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about racial pride destroying love? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. ("belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery", Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes racial pride destroying love. Key takeaway: race is shown as a social construction.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** The man who rejects his wife for her "race" is himself of mixed ancestry.
- **Foreshadowing:** Armand's darkness, his mother living in Paris.
- **Characterization:** Armand's cruelty to enslaved people and his love that turns to hate.

Themes and how they develop

- **racism and identity:** race is shown as a social construction.

Symbols and motifs

- **the bonfire:** Armand burning her things, trying to destroy the evidence.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26) The accusation.
- “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30) Désirée's letter.
- “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50) The final letter.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism.
Evidence: “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50)
Reasoning: Armand accuses Désirée, "it means that you are not white," but the final letter shows his own mother "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
muslins (noun)	plain-woven cotton fabric	*The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.*	
avalanche (noun)	a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain	*The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.*	
narrowly (adverb)	closely; carefully	*She scanned the baby narrowly, then looked as searchingly at Zandrine, whose face was turned to gaze across the fields.*	“narrowly”: Origin: an English formation from narrow + -ly. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/narrowly#Etymology)

obstacles (noun)	things that stand in the way	*The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.*	"obstacles": Origin of "obstacle": Old French obstacle; earlier Latin obstāculum. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/obstacle#Etymology)
unjustly (adverb)	in an unjust manner	*He thought Almighty God had dealt cruelly and unjustly with him; and felt, somehow, that he was paying Him back in kind when he stabbed thus into his wife's soul.*	"unjustly": Origin: an English formation from unjust + -ly. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/unjustly#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. How can a single fact change how people treat someone they love?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with race and identity?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How did Désirée come to the Valmondés? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: She was found as a baby by a stone pillar
2. What is L'Abri like? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: A gloomy, sad-looking plantation
3. What change does Désirée notice in the baby? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Signs of African ancestry
4. What does Armand burn? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Désirée's belongings in a bonfire
5. What does the final letter reveal? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Armand's mother was of African descent
6. Retell the three most important events of "Désirée's Baby" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Désirée, a foundling raised by the Valmondés, marries the proud planter Armand Aubigny. When their baby begins to show African ancestry, Armand turns cold and sends her away; she walks with the baby into the bayou and does not return. Burning her things, Armand finds a letter from his own mother, revealing that she belonged to 'the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery.'
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "Désirée's Baby"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.

8. Where and when does “Désirée's Baby” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.” What does “muslins” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: muslins: plain-woven cotton fabric.
10. Reread: “The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.” What does “avalanche” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: avalanche: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Désirée's Baby” suggest about racial pride destroying love? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Its final reversal exposes the arbitrariness of racial categories.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about racial pride destroying love? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26): The accusation. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “It was no wonder, when she stood one day against the stone pillar in whose shadow she had lain asleep, eighteen years before, that Armand Aubigny riding by and seeing her there,…”, why might Chopin have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Désirée's Baby”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Désirée, a foundling raised by the Valmondés, marries the proud planter Armand Aubigny. When their baby begins to show African ancestry, Armand turns cold and sends her away; she walks with the baby into the bayou and does not return. Burning her things, Armand finds a letter from his own mother,…
6. As the opening story, what does “Désirée's Baby” set up that the rest of Désirée's Baby will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30): Désirée's letter. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50): The final letter. On characterization: Armand's cruelty to enslaved people and his love that turns to hate. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “How can a single fact change how people treat someone they love?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with race and identity? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26): The accusation. On characterization: Armand's cruelty to enslaved people and his love that turns to hate. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in Vogue in 1893 and set in antebellum Louisiana, where Creole society enforced rigid racial classification. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30): Désirée's letter. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Its final reversal exposes the arbitrariness of racial categories.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50): The final letter. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26): The accusation. On characterization: Armand's cruelty to enslaved people and his love that turns to hate. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Désirée's Baby” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about racial pride destroying love? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30): Désirée's letter. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “Désirée's Baby”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50): The final letter. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to pride and cruelty: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Chopin need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26): The accusation. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30): Désirée's letter. On irony: The man who rejects his wife for her "race" is himself of mixed ancestry. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “Désirée's Baby” treats racial pride destroying love with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Désirée's Baby see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50): The final letter. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve race and identity? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26): The accusation. On foreshadowing: Armand's darkness, his mother living in Paris. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about racial pride destroying love? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30): Désirée's letter. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Kate Chopin about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Useful evidence: "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery" (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50): The final letter. Theme link: race is shown as a social construction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What change does Désirée notice in the baby?

   A. Signs of African ancestry

   B. Blindness

   C. An illness

   D. A birthmark

   Key: A (Signs of African ancestry)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 17? "Marriage, and later the birth of his son had softened Armand Aubigny's _____ and exacting nature greatly."

   A. disquieting

   B. disfigured

   C. imperious

   D. presence

   Key: C (imperious)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is L'Abri like?

   A. A riverboat

   B. A cheerful town house

   C. A convent

   D. A gloomy, sad-looking plantation

   Key: D (A gloomy, sad-looking plantation)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "He thought Almighty God had dealt cruelly and _____ with him; and felt, somehow, that he was paying Him back in kind when he stabbed thus into his wife's soul." Word bank: narrowly, unjustly, muslins, avalanche

   Key: unjustly

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 3? “For the girl grew to be beautiful and gentle, _____ and sincere,--the idol of Valmondé.”

   A. little

   B. proudest

   C. affectionate

   D. reaching

   Key: C (affectionate)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How did Désirée come to the Valmondés?

   A. She was found as a baby by a stone pillar

   B. She was a cousin

   C. She was adopted from a convent

   D. She was born there

   Key: A (She was found as a baby by a stone pillar)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 6: “Big, solemn oaks grew close to it, and their thick-leaved, far-_____ branches shadowed it like a pall.” Word bank: tenderly, disquieting, reaching, averted

   Key: reaching

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the final letter reveal?

   A. His father was alive

   B. The baby was not his

   C. Désirée was rich

   D. Armand's mother was of African descent

   Key: D (Armand's mother was of African descent)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Armand burn?

   A. The cradle only

   B. The letters of his father

   C. Désirée's belongings in a bonfire

   D. His house

   Key: C (Désirée's belongings in a bonfire)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50: “_____ to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery”

    Key: belongs

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 17 reveal about the character or situation? “This was what made the gentle Désirée so happy, for she loved him desperately.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 17) shows the situation turning on pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. The words “desperately” and “gentle” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 45 reveal about the character or situation? “She walked across a deserted field, where the stubble bruised her tender feet, so delicately shod, and tore her thin gown to shreds.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 45) shows the situation turning on pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. The words “delicately” and “deserted” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which of these passages comes earliest in the story?

    A. “Why, it seemed but yesterday that Désirée was little more than a baby herself; when Monsieur in riding through the gateway of Valmondé had…”

    B. “As the day was pleasant, Madame Valmondé drove over to L'Abri to see Désirée and the baby.”

    C. “Some people thought she might have strayed there of her own accord, for she was of the toddling age.”

    D. “The little one awoke in his arms and began to cry for ‘Dada.’ That was as much as she could do or say.”

    Key: B (“As the day was pleasant, Madame Valmondé drove over to L'Abri to see Désirée and the baby.”)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 19 shapes its tone: “She looked from her child to the boy who stood beside him, and back again; over and over.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “beside” and “looked” (paragraph 19) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 49 shapes its tone: “The last thing to go was a tiny bundle of letters; innocent little scribblings that Désirée had sent to him during the days of their espousal.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “scribblings” and “espousal” (paragraph 49) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The claim is persuasive in part. “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50) supports it: Armand accuses Désirée, "it means that you are not white," but the final letter shows his own mother "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery.". But “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30) complicates it: the line (Désirée's letter) shows the same issue from another side, and its “not” marks a limit or reversal the claim passes over. Weighing the two passages, the claim survives, but only once it admits the tension the second passage creates.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 18: “When he spoke to her, it was with _____ eyes, from which the old love-light seemed to have gone out.” Word bank: reaching, imperious, averted, speaking
    Key: averted

18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 18 shapes its tone: “He absented himself from home; and when there, avoided her presence and that of her child, without excuse.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “presence” and “absented” (paragraph 18) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 3 shapes its tone: “Some people thought she might have strayed there of her own accord, for she was of the toddling age.”

Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “toddling” and “strayed” (paragraph 3) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Connect this passage from paragraph 6 to the story's treatment of pride and cruelty: “Young Aubigny's rule was a strict one, too, and under it his negroes had forgotten how to be gay, as they had been during the old master's easy-going and indulgent lifetime.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 6) develops pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “indulgent” and “forgotten” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Armand heard him the other day as far away as La Blanche's cabin.’” (paragraph 12), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating pride and cruelty as central.

21. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 1: “As the day was _____, Madame Valmondé drove over to L'Abri to see Désirée and the baby.” Word bank: sumptuous, imperious, pleasant, reaching

    Key: pleasant

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The accusation. The evidence is “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26). This develops racism and identity: race is shown as a social construction. The words “white” and “means” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Armand accuses Désirée, "it means that you are not white," but the final letter shows his own mother "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery.".

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Désirée's letter. The evidence is “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30). This develops racism and identity: race is shown as a social construction. The words “white” and “they” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Armand accuses Désirée, "it means that you are not white," but the final letter shows his own mother "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery.".

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3] Connect this passage from paragraph 33 to the story's treatment of pride and cruelty: “She was like a stone image: silent, white, motionless after she placed it there.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 33) develops pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “motionless” and “silent” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “She took the little one from the nurse's arms with no word of explanation, and descending the steps, walked away, under…” (paragraph 43), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating pride and cruelty as central.

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3] Synthesis: trace how racism and identity develops from the opening of “Désirée's Baby” to its ending. Use one quotation from each part.

    Sample answer: Near the start, “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26) — The accusation. Later, “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50) — The final letter. Race is shown as a social construction.

26. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3] What can you infer from this line? “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The accusation. The evidence is “it means that you are not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 26). This develops racism and identity: race is shown as a social construction.

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3] Connect this passage from paragraph 5 to the story's treatment of pride and cruelty: “He ordered the corbeille from Paris, and contained himself with what patience he could until it arrived; then they were married.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 5) develops pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “contained” and “corbeille” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “When she reached L'Abri she shuddered at the first sight of it, as she always did.” (paragraph 6), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating pride and cruelty as central.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3] Connect this passage from paragraph 22 to the story's treatment of pride and cruelty: “Presently her husband entered the room, and without noticing her, went to a table and began to search among some papers which covered it.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 22) develops pride and cruelty: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “noticing” and “without” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “A quick conception of all that this accusation meant for her nerved her with unwonted courage to deny it.” (paragraph 27), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating pride and cruelty as central.

29. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2] Which literary element does this describe in “Désirée's Baby”? Armand's darkness, his mother living in Paris.

    A. Allusion

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Alliteration

    D. Diction / vocabulary

    Key: B (Foreshadowing)

30. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] What can you infer from this line? “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Désirée's letter. The evidence is “they tell me I am not white” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 30). This develops racism and identity: race is shown as a social construction.

31. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Claim: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50).

    Sample answer: Armand accuses Désirée, "it means that you are not white," but the final letter shows his own mother "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery.". The evidence is “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50). This develops racism and identity: race is shown as a social construction.

32. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] In the line “She scanned the baby narrowly, then looked as searchingly at Zandrine, whose face was turned to gaze across the fields.”, what does “narrowly” most nearly mean?

    A. closely; carefully

    B. plain-woven cotton fabric

    C. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    D. things that stand in the way

    Key: A (closely; carefully)

33. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Désirée's Baby”? The man who rejects his wife for her ‘race’ is himself of mixed ancestry.

    A. Irony

    B. Personification

    C. Symbolism

    D. Setting

    Key: A (Irony)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 17, 6, 7, 9, 4, 3, 1, 8, 13, 11, 12, 14, 18, 19, 20	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	17, 10, 2, 1, 21, 3, 5, 9, 11, 13, 12, 19, 18, 15, 22, 23	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 21, 7, 1, 2, 5, 10, 13, 11, 12, 19, 18, 15, 14, 24, 25	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	6, 21, 4, 9, 8, 26, 13, 12, 11, 14, 15, 19, 18, 24, 27, 28	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	6, 17, 21, 3, 13, 11, 26, 14, 18, 15, 19, 29, 28, 16, 24, 23	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Freshman	3, 1, 6, 4, 21, 30, 13, 18, 14, 19, 31, 15, 27, 24, 20, 28	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	9, 32, 4, 10, 13, 33, 18, 19, 14, 15, 20, 22, 23, 16, 24, 28	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Junior	6, 5, 4, 10, 13, 26, 29, 15, 18, 14, 19, 20, 28, 27, 24, 16	recall 4, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	3, 4, 10, 6, 13, 19, 14, 33, 18, 24, 27, 23, 16, 28, 22, 20	recall 4, inference 1, analysis 4, synthesis 7
Graduate / PhD	2, 4, 10, 6, 13, 30, 11, 12, 33, 18, 19, 16, 28, 20, 27, 24	recall 4, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Désirée's Baby,” how does Chopin show racial pride destroying love? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): In Désirée's Baby, how does Chopin develop the idea of racial pride destroying love? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Analyze how Désirée's Baby develops the idea of racial pride destroying love. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Désirée's Baby (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of racial pride destroying love. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Désirée's Baby suggests about racial pride destroying love. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Kate Chopin uses irony in Désirée's Baby to complicate the reader's understanding of racial pride destroying love. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Situate Désirée's Baby within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of racial pride destroying love responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Read Désirée's Baby alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of racial pride destroying love follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Désirée's Baby and its treatment of racial pride destroying love. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Désirée's Baby as evidence for a larger claim about racial pride destroying love in Désirée's Baby. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Désirée's Baby as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of racial pride destroying love. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Désirée's Baby.

SAT-style questions

1. *The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “muslins” most nearly mean?

   A. closely; carefully

   B. plain-woven cotton fabric

   C. in an unjust manner

   D. things that stand in the way

2. *It was no wonder, when she stood one day against the stone pillar in whose shadow she had lain asleep, eighteen years before, that Armand Aubigny riding by and seeing her there, had fallen in love with her. That was the way all the Aubignys fell in love, as if struck by a pistol shot. The wonder was that he had not loved her before; for he had known her since his father brought him home from Paris, a boy of eight, after his mother died there. The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Désirée's Baby"?

A. Racial pride destroying love

B. The closing of the frontier

C. Superstition used against a credulous man

D. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

SAT key: 1. B (plain-woven cotton fabric); 2. A (Racial pride destroying love)

Unit test

Désirée's Baby: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 19: “The baby, half naked, lay asleep upon her own great mahogany bed, that was like a _____ throne, with its satin-lined half-canopy.” Word bank: little, presence, proudest, sumptuous

   Key: sumptuous

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 6? “It was a sad looking place, which for many years had not known the gentle _____ of a mistress, old Monsieur Aubigny having married and buried his wife in France, and she having loved her own land too well ever to leave it.”

   A. tenderly
   B. sumptuous
   C. pleasant
   D. presence

   Key: D (presence)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 18? “And the very spirit of Satan seemed _____ to take hold of him in his dealings with the slaves.”

   A. proudest
   B. suddenly
   C. disfigured
   D. reaching

   Key: B (suddenly)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 3? “The _____ one awoke in his arms and began to cry for ‘Dada.’ That was as much as she could do or say.”

   A. little
   B. averted
   C. affectionate
   D. prevailing

   Key: A (little)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 18? “It had only been a _____ suggestion; an air of mystery among the blacks; unexpected visits from far-off neighbors who could hardly account for their coming.”

   A. prevailing

   B. disquieting

   C. pleasant

   D. tenderly

   Key: B (disquieting)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 8? “Madame Valmondé bent her portly figure over Désirée and kissed her, holding her an instant _____ in her arms.”

   A. tenderly

   B. prevailing

   C. little

   D. disquieting

   Key: A (tenderly)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 3: “The _____ belief was that she had been purposely left by a party of Texans, whose canvas-covered wagon, late in the day, had crossed the ferry that Coton Mais kept, just below the plantation.” Word bank: sumptuous, tenderly, prevailing, speaking

   Key: prevailing

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 16: “And mamma,’ she added, drawing Madame Valmondé's head down to her, and _____ in a whisper, ‘he hasn't punished one of them--not one of them--since baby is born.” Word bank: pleasant, speaking, tenderly, sumptuous

   Key: speaking

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 17: “But Armand's dark, handsome face had not often been _____ by frowns since the day he fell in love with her.” Word bank: tenderly, averted, proudest, disfigured

   Key: disfigured

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 5: “What did it matter about a name when he could give her one of the oldest and _____ in Louisiana?” Word bank: proudest, reaching, little, imperious

    Key: proudest

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 19 reveal about the character or situation? “One of La Blanche's little quadroon boys--half naked too--stood fanning the child slowly with a fan of peacock feathers.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 19) shows the situation turning on race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. The words “feathers” and “quadroon” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 6 reveal about the character or situation? “When she reached L'Abri she shuddered at the first sight of it, as she always did.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 6) shows the situation turning on slavery: race is shown as a social construction. The words “shuddered” and “reached” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 2 reveal about the character or situation? “Why, it seemed but yesterday that Désirée was little more than a baby herself; when Monsieur in riding through the gateway of Valmondé had found her lying asleep in the shadow of the big stone pillar.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 2) shows the situation turning on race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. The words “yesterday” and “gateway” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 27 reveal about the character or situation? “A quick conception of all that this accusation meant for her nerved her with unwonted courage to deny it.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 27) shows the situation turning on slavery: race is shown as a social construction. The words “accusation” and “conception” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 29 shapes its tone: “When she could hold a pen in her hand, she sent a despairing letter to Madame Valmondé.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “despairing” and “letter” (paragraph 29) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 12 shapes its tone: “Armand heard him the other day as far away as La Blanche's cabin.’” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words its wording (paragraph 12) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to slavery: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 6 shapes its tone: “The roof came down steep and black like a cowl, reaching out beyond the wide galleries that encircled the yellow stuccoed house.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “galleries” and “encircled” (paragraph 6) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Connect this passage from paragraph 3 to the story's treatment of slavery: “In time Madame Valmondé abandoned every speculation but the one that Désirée had been sent to her by a beneficent Providence to be the child of her affection, seeing that she was without child of the flesh.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 3) develops slavery: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “speculation” and “beneficent” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Monsieur Valmondé grew practical and wanted things well considered: that is, the girl's obscure origin.” (paragraph 5), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating slavery as central.

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 43 shapes its tone: “She took the little one from the nurse's arms with no word of explanation, and descending the steps, walked away, under the live-oak branches.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “explanation” and “descending” (paragraph 43) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than

neutral. That weight points the reader to slavery: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Connect this passage from paragraph 48 to the story's treatment of race and identity: “Agraceful cradle of willow, with all its dainty furbishings, was laid upon the pyre, which had already been fed with the richness of a priceless layette.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 48) develops race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “furbishings” and “priceless” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “The last thing to go was a tiny bundle of letters; innocent little scribblings that Désirée had sent to him during the…” (paragraph 49), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating race and identity as central.
21. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 18 shapes its tone: “When the baby was about three months old, Désirée awoke one day to the conviction that there was something in the air menacing her peace.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “conviction” and “something” (paragraph 18) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to slavery: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Connect this passage from paragraph 45 to the story's treatment of race and identity: “Her hair was uncovered and the sun's rays brought a golden gleam from its brown meshes.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 45) develops race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “uncovered” and “brought” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “She walked across a deserted field, where the stubble bruised her tender feet, so delicately shod, and tore her thin…” (paragraph 45), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating race and identity as central.
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3] Connect this passage from paragraph 20 to the story's treatment of slavery: “She tried to speak to the little quadroon boy; but no sound would come, at first.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 20) develops slavery: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “quadroon” and “little” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “He laid aside the great, soft fan, and obediently stole away, over the polished floor, on his bare tiptoes.” (paragraph 20), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating slavery as central.
24. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 5 shapes its tone: “Monsieur Valmondé grew practical and wanted things well considered: that is, the girl's obscure origin.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “considered” and “practical” (paragraph 5) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3] Connect this passage from paragraph 19 to the story's treatment of slavery: “She sat in her room, one hot afternoon, in her peignoir, listlessly drawing through her fingers the strands of her long, silky brown hair that hung about her shoulders.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 19) develops slavery: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “listlessly” and “afternoon” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “One of La Blanche's little quadroon boys--half naked too--stood fanning the child slowly with a fan of peacock feathers.” (paragraph 19), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating slavery as central.

26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3] Connect this passage from paragraph 18 to the story's treatment of race and identity: “Then a strange, an awful change in her husband's manner, which she dared not ask him to explain.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 18) develops race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “husband's” and “explain” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “He absented himself from home; and when there, avoided her presence and that of her child, without excuse.” (paragraph 18), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating race and identity as central.

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO1] In the line “The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.”, what does “muslins” most nearly mean?

    A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    B. things that stand in the way

    C. closely; carefully

    D. plain-woven cotton fabric

    Key: D (plain-woven cotton fabric)

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 47 shapes its tone: “In the centre of the smoothly swept back yard was a great bonfire.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “smoothly” and “bonfire” (paragraph 47) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to slavery: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 20 shapes its tone: “He laid aside the great, soft fan, and obediently stole away, over the polished floor, on his bare tiptoes.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “obediently” and “polished” (paragraph 20) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3] Connect this passage from paragraph 49 to the story's treatment of slavery: “But it was not Désirée's; it was part of an old letter from his mother to his father.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 49) develops slavery: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “father” and “letter” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Why, it seemed but yesterday that Désirée was little more than a baby herself; when Monsieur in riding through the…” (paragraph 2), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating slavery as central.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Connect this passage from paragraph 16 to the story's treatment of race and identity: “Even Negrillon, who pretended to have burnt his leg that he might rest from work--he only laughed, and said Negrillon was a great scamp. oh, mamma, I'm so happy; it frightens me.'” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 16) develops race and identity: race is shown as a social construction. Its words “pretended” and “frightens” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “This was what made the gentle Désirée so happy, for she loved him desperately.” (paragraph 17), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating race and identity as central.

32. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] In the line "The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.", what does "avalanche" most nearly mean?

    A. plain-woven cotton fabric

    B. closely; carefully

    C. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    D. things that stand in the way

    Key: C (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain)

33. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] In the line "The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.", what does "obstacles" most nearly mean?

    A. plain-woven cotton fabric

    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    C. things that stand in the way

    D. closely; carefully

    Key: C (things that stand in the way)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 10, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	10, 4, 5, 6, 8, 3, 9, 2, 7, 1, 13, 14, 11, 12, 15, 17, 19, 20	recall 10, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	9, 3, 1, 10, 8, 6, 4, 2, 5, 11, 13, 12, 14, 19, 15, 21, 22, 18	recall 9, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 8, 10, 6, 7, 2, 1, 3, 13, 14, 12, 11, 15, 16, 19, 17, 18, 23	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	10, 2, 1, 4, 7, 5, 6, 12, 13, 11, 14, 24, 17, 15, 19, 20, 25, 26	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	8, 10, 2, 27, 12, 11, 14, 28, 21, 15, 17, 16, 29, 30, 23, 22, 18, 25	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Freshman	2, 5, 8, 14, 12, 11, 13, 28, 21, 17, 19, 29, 16, 23, 22, 18, 31, 26	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	5, 8, 27, 12, 11, 13, 19, 15, 16, 24, 28, 17, 23, 25, 31, 30, 22, 26	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 6, synthesis 6
College Junior	10, 27, 32, 14, 28, 21, 16, 17, 29, 15, 22, 18, 31, 23, 25, 20, 30, 26	recall 3, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 8
College Senior	5, 7, 27, 11, 29, 19, 24, 17, 28, 21, 20, 30, 23, 26, 25, 31, 22, 18	recall 3, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 8
Graduate / PhD	10, 27, 33, 24, 16, 29, 28, 21, 19, 15, 31, 20, 23, 25, 18, 26, 22, 30	recall 3, inference 0, analysis 7, synthesis 8

Final paper

Désirée's Baby: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Kate Chopin develops race and identity across Désirée's Baby. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in Désirée's Baby and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to pride and cruelty.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in Désirée's Baby. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether Désirée's Baby finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of slavery. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor	Exemplary	Proficient	Developing	Beginning
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.	Specific, arguable and precise; it organizes every section.	Clear and arguable, but broad in places.	States a topic or a summary more than an argument.	Missing, or restates the prompt.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.	Accurate, well-chosen quotations from across the work, all cited; meets the requirement.	Accurate and cited, but clustered in one part of the work.	Too few quotations, or some inaccurate or uncited.	Little or no quoted evidence.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.	Explains how specific words, structure and devices create meaning; weighs a competing reading.	Explains the evidence, with some close reading.	Mostly summary; the link to the claim is asserted, not shown.	Summary only.
Organization	15					

		Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.	Each paragraph advances the argument; transitions show logic.	Logical order with minor jumps.	Order is loose; paragraphs repeat or drift.	No discernible structure.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.	Formal, precise, present tense; MLA format; virtually error-free.	Formal with a few errors that do not obscure meaning.	Informal or error-prone in ways that distract.	Errors obscure meaning.

Exemplar paragraph: Chopin uses irony to expose the illogic of racism. The text makes this visible when it says “belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery” (Désirée's Baby, paragraph 50). Armand accuses Désirée, "it means that you are not white," but the final letter shows his own mother "belongs to the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery.". A full paper would carry this reading through the beginning, middle and end, and answer the strongest competing reading.

Essay assignments

Essay: Race and identity

Scaffolded support (600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Désirée's Baby teaches about race and identity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops race and identity in Désirée's Baby. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops race and identity across Désirée's Baby. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Désirée's Baby (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of race and identity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of race and identity in Désirée's Baby. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in Désirée's Baby (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of race and identity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Désirée's Baby's treatment of race and identity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on race and identity in Désirée's Baby that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on race and identity in Désirée's Baby. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about race and identity in Désirée's Baby, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on race and identity in Désirée's Baby, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Pride and cruelty

Scaffolded support (600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Désirée's Baby teaches about pride and cruelty. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops pride and cruelty across Désirée's Baby. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Désirée's Baby (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of pride and cruelty. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in Désirée's Baby (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of pride and cruelty, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Désirée's Baby's treatment of pride and cruelty in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Slavery

Scaffolded support (600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Désirée's Baby teaches about slavery. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops slavery in Désirée's Baby. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops slavery across Désirée's Baby. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Désirée's Baby (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of slavery. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of slavery in Désirée's Baby. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in Désirée's Baby (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of slavery, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Désirée's Baby's treatment of slavery in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on slavery in Désirée's Baby that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on slavery in Désirée's Baby. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about slavery in Désirée's Baby, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on slavery in Désirée's Baby, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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